were right there in the congress hall, led by Zhou Enlai, the long-serving head of the Chinese communist government. A few days before the removal of Stalin's corpse from the mausoleum, Zhou had placed a wreath at his coffin. The inscription referred to Stalin as "the great Marxist-Leninist." The two communist countries were in a growing conflict over Khrushchev's de-Stalinization policy and his attack on Stalin's "cult of personality," which was interpreted by China's communist leader and Khrushchev's challenger, Mao Zedong, as an attack on him and his regime.

At the congress Zhou Enlai criticized the Soviets for being soft on the West, while Khrushchev argued that his policy of "peaceful coexistence," adopted a few years earlier, was working and could be criticized only by "hopeless dogmatists." A CIA study of Soviet-Chinese relations that focused intensely on the party congress in Moscow summarized the tensions between Moscow and Beijing (called Peiping in the paper) as follows. "Although these differences had not usually been stated polemically in 1961, the Soviet party had continued to favor an opportunistic strategy of softening Western resistance by peaceful gestures while exploiting indigenous political movements in non-Communist countries primarily by non-military means, whereas the Chinese party had continued to advocate a more militant revolutionary program for the world movement on all fronts, particularly in the underdeveloped areas. Moscow contended that the bloc should not accept serious risks of world war, while Peiping argued that a more militant program would not increase the existing risk."[4]

The two communist leaders, Khrushchev and Mao Zedong, also competed for leadership of the world communist movement and influence in the Third World. No Third World country received more attention at the Moscow congress than Fidel Castro's Cuba, which half a year earlier had repelled the American-backed invasion and was represented at the congress by a delegation of Cuban communists. "Under the leadership of the courageous patriot and revolutionary Fidel Castro, the Cubans quickly routed the American hirelings, driving them into the Bahía de Cochinos, which means 'Bay of Pigs' in Russian. That's where they belong!" declared Khrushchev. The congress of the "builders of communism" exploded in laughter and applause. Khrushchev spared no effort to praise the "anti-